

CREDITED WITH THE SUCCESS of three of the top 5 highest-grossing pan-India films of all time, Writer and Director **S.S. Rajamouli's** creations have tasted amazing success at the box office. Having come out of the stables of the south Indian film industry, his films, *Baahubali: The Beginning* (2015), *Baahubali 2: The Conclusion* (2017), and *RRR* (2022) have broken through the shackles of language, culture, and geographies, to appeal to all classes of the very selective Indian audiences, ranging from the multiplex crowd to the single-screen regulars. *Business Today* recently caught up with the 48-year-old Hyderabad-based film-maker to hear him decode his winning formula. Edited excerpts:

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Why do you think the films that you've originally made in Telugu have worked so well in Hindi?

The first thing is that I don't differentiate between Hindi and Telugu. I am trying to talk in the visual language, and not in the language that the actors are speaking. Language is just a medium of talking. That's one part of communication, but the bigger communication is happening through visuals in my films. I don't want to see language as a barrier.

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Does Bollywood need to rethink its content strategy?

There's no good and bad; it's bigger successes and lesser successes. Even Hindi films have had successes in the last six months; it's not like every Hindi film has been unsuccessful.

Also, it's not like every film from the South has done well. But what [has] happened is that the

entertainment felt a bit left out. In Telugu, Tamil or Kannada we had to do that [make such films] because we're making films only for one state, and we have to get all audiences into the theatres. We kept on making those kind of films, and these films reached people in north Indian states, who were not getting the kind of entertainment they wanted. This happened for a long

budgets, but once I start working on the story, I don't think anything about the economics, I just let my mind go free. I develop whatever I want to, and once everything is done, we look at the economics: how much is this going to cost? How much will the market value be? Are we within a reasonable distance? That will be a long discussion, and if I need to trim in some places, I will trim, and if I can

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success of south Indian movies has been much bigger than the success of the Hindi film industry during this season. They have outperformed. As film-makers, we can't take all the credit as it's also the audience.

For many years now, from the '90s, the Hindi film industry has travelled more towards the lighter veined, heart-warming, subtle kind of storytelling. They have done great films and had big successes in love and romance genres.

But a large number of people who love action films and hardcore

time, for a period of 20-25 years, without any of us knowing.

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How do you strike a balance between creativity and commerce?

I am aware of what the economics of a film are. It is not that I blindly increase the budgets and go ahead with them. I strongly believe that the director and producer have to collectively take a decision and go forward. So, basically art and commerce both have to travel together. The way I do it is, I generally have a rough idea of the

go broader on some areas, I will. I am very well aware of the economics, but I let the art do the driving and let the economics follow.

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What was the distribution and dubbing strategy behind RRR? How did you go about choosing the markets within north India?

As a storyteller, I want my story to be seen by different kinds of audiences; by a large number of people. So, how do I make my story understood by more number of people? The automatic decision is to dub it into a language that